SEEDLING

Read the lines from the poem ‘The Seedling’ and answer the questions that follow.

As a quiet little seedling
Lay within its darksome bed,
To itself it fell a-talking,
And this is what it said:
“I am not so very robust,
But I’ll do the best I can;”
And the seedling from that moment
Its work of life began.

1. Where was the seedling located at the beginning of the poem?
   A) In a vibrant garden
   B) Within a darksome bed
   C) On a sunny windowsill
   D) Under a flowing stream
2. What does the seedling’s admission that it is "not so very robust" suggest?
3. “To itself it fell a-talking,” Why is this line crucial to the theme of the poem?
4. When did the seedling’s work of life begin?

DE KOLAM

Answers:

SET 1

1. B) Within a darksome bed
2. It suggests that it is not the strength but the mindset that makes success.
3. This line represents self-determination.
4. When it took the decision to do its best.

APPRECIATION

THE SEEDLING -PAUL LAURENCE DUNBAR

Paul Laurence Dunbar stands out as a significant American poet renowned for his impactful poetry that often explores themes of hope, struggle, and resilience. His work reflects a profound insight into both life and nature. “The Seedling” is a concise yet meaningful poem that employs a seedling as a powerful symbol for human life and growth. The central theme centres on patience, perseverance and hope, suggesting that genuine growth takes time and often goes unnoticed by others.

In the poem, Dunbar paints a vivid picture of a small seedling hidden beneath the soil. This seedling does not grow rapidly or draw attention to itself, but it is very much alive and brimming with potential. It patiently gathers strength in silence, and though external observers may see no evidence of progress, the seedling is steadily developing beneath the surface. At the right moment, it breaks through the soil, emerging strong and vibrant. This imagery draws a beautiful comparison betweenthe seedling and human beings, particularly those who quietly endure challenges and cultivate their strength over time. The poem imparts a valuable lesson: true success is rarely instantaneous, and patience is essential for authentic growth.

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Dunbar skillfully employs various poetic devices throughout the poem. The poem follows an ABAB rhyme scheme, with “seedling” rhyming with “talking” and “bed” rhyming with “said”. Similarly, “robust” rhymes with “moment”, “can” with “began”, and “day” with “way”. Symbolism plays a pivotal role, as the seedling represents human life and inner development. A seedling symbolises human potential and resilience. Light symbolises hope, success, and enlightenment. Soil/darkness symbolise life’s struggles. Vivid imagery allows readers to visualise the seed's hidden journey and gradual emergence. Alliteration is used in the words “planting, pushing, patiently”, where the repeated ‘p’ sound adds rhythm and makes the line more musical. Additionally, personification “pushing toward the light, “enriches the poem as the seedling is depicted as waiting and growing with patience. The use of simple language and a calm tone contributes to the clarity and effectiveness of the message.

I find “The Seedling” to be an uplifting poem that inspires hope and patience, especially during challenging times. Dunbar beautifully reminds us that quiet determination and perseverance will ultimately lead to success.

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LANGUAGE ELEMENTS

I. Fill in the blanks with the right phrasal verbs from the brackets

1. (Pour out , Done away with, Ended up, Looked down on, put up with)

"When I was born without eyes, society (a) _____ _____ me as a burden. Some even suggested that I should be (b) _____ _____. But my parents (c) _____ _____ me with immense love and care. They felt they were the richest couple in the world, and I feel I have (d) _____ _____ as the luckiest person.

2. [put in, pay off, give in, go on, give up, get on]

Bablu didn't want to ……(a)…….. to the flak he was receiving from the people. He had already made up his mind that he won't ……(b)…….. his dream. So, he ……(c)....experimenting even though his wife and mother were against him. The efforts he …….(d)…….didn't go futile. Finally, his dedication ……(e)…….. when he made affordable napkins for women.

II. Complete the following passage choosing the right words from those given in brackets.

1. (with,under,to,of,than,for,in)

When I completed my 10th grade (a) _____ over 90% marks, I wanted to study science (b) _____ the A.P. State Board. However, I was told I could only take arts because I was 'impaired.' I did not consider myself visually impaired but visually 'challenged.' I was not allowed to pursue my passion due (c) _____ the perceptions (d) _____ others. Rather (e) _____ accept this, I decided to sue the government (f) _____ my rights.

III. Edit the following passage.

That evening to (a) his way back from the workshop, Bablu decided to surprise Gowri with a gift.

He gone (b) to a small store. The store keeper quickly wrapped an (c) napkin packed in an old newspaper. Bablu was startled at the exorbetent (d) price, but dutifully paid him forty rupees. He unwrapped the packet but (e) examined the pad. It seems (f) to be just a plain cotton wrapped in a gauze sheet.

2. Eventually, my parents and relatives decide (a) that I should study in a school for (b) students like me. So, I had (c) sent to a special school in Hyderabad. There I exsceled (d), becoming an outstanding student, earning top ranks, and representing india (e) in chess and cricket. I had a (f) privilege of working with Dr A.P.J. Abdul Kalam.

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IV. Complete the dialogue suitably.

1. Bablu : I am trying to help rural women, ____?

Mother : Bablu, why _____?

Bablu : If I stop my work now, _____.

Mother : You had better _____.

Bablu : Can't I work for a better cause?

Mother : No Bablu. You work as if _____.

2. Complete the following conversation between Arunachalam Muruganantham and Shanti.

Muruganantham : You really appreciate my attempts, ……(a).....?

Shanti : It's not really so.

Muruganantham : ……..(b).....?

Shanti : You waste time on mad experiments.

Muruganantham : ……(c).....?

Shanti : Yes. Our family faces disgrace by your sordid interest.

Muruganantham : But, Shanti, I am doing it with a good intention

Shanti : If you continue with your nonsense, ……(d).....

Muruganantham : You had better ……..(e).....

Shanti : I cannot agree with everything you do

2. (a) don't you? (b) What makes you oppose me? (c) Do you feel our family faces disgrace by my sordid interest? (d) I will leave this house. (e) agree with my experiments

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V. Report the following dialogue.

1. Srikanth : How can they deny me admission on such grounds?

Teacher : Don't worry. We will get a clarification on it.

2. Bablu : Why didn't you use the product I invented?

Gowri : I found it annoying. It is disgusting too.

VI. Identify the Noun Phrase in the subject position and the Verb Phrase in the sentence below.

1. My short legs made it difficult for me to help.
2. Bablu's mother and younger sister, Shalu, were drinking tea.
3. All my initial experiments failed miserably.
4. My profit margin is based on need, not greed.

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LANGUAGE ELEMENTS ANSWERS

I. Answers

1. (a) Looked down on (b) Done away with (c) Pour out (d) Ended up

2.(a) give in (b) give up (c) went on (d) put in (e) paid off

II. Answers

1. (a) with (d) under (c)to (d) of (e) than (f)for

III. Answers

1. (a) on (b) went (c) the (d) exorbitant (e) and (f) seemed

2. (a) decided (b) with (c) was (d) excelled (e) India (f) the

IV. Answers

1. (a) aren't I? (b). are you doing these experiments (c). women will continue to suffer (d). take rest (e) you were a scientist

V. Answers

1. Srikanth asked the teacher how they could deny him admission on such grounds.
The teacher advised Srikanth not to worry and added that they would get a clarification on it.

2. Bablu asked Gowri why she hadn't used the product he had invented.
Gowri replied that she had found it annoying and added that it was disgusting too.

VI. Answers

1. My short legs – NP
made it difficult for me to help – VP
2. Bablu's mother and younger sister, Shalu– NP
were drinking tea – VP
3. All my initial experiments– NP
failed miserably – VP
4. My profit margin– NP
is based on need, not greed. – VP

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